Two for the Row'd

November 2026

HIDDEN GEMS & HISTORY

Ireland's Ancient East, Hidden Gems & Christmas Magic

This month we explore Carlow's finest castles and country estates, discover the Delta Sensory Gardens and find festive inspiration at Europe's most enchanting Christmas markets. Pull up a chair — there's plenty to explore.



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INSIDE: DELTA SENSORY GARDENS • HUNTINGTON CASTLE • WELLS HOUSE • STRADBALLY HALL • CHRISTMAS MARKETS

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Delta Sensory Gardens

Tucked away in the heart of County Carlow, Delta Sensory Gardens is one of those quietly wonderful places that rewards the curious traveller. Spread across beautifully landscaped grounds, this hidden gem is designed to delight every sense — from the gentle sound of water features trickling through sculpted beds to the vivid bursts of colour that greet you around every corner.

Whether you are a keen gardener, a lover of peaceful open spaces, or simply someone in need of a restorative afternoon away from the everyday, Delta Sensory Gardens delivers something genuinely special. The gardens have been thoughtfully laid out to create a series of distinct spaces, each with its own mood and character, yet all flowing naturally into one another.



A Garden for Every Sense

The sensory experience here is the real draw. Fragrant planting fills the air with lavender, rosemary and sweet blossom depending on the season, while the textures underfoot and along the pathways invite you to slow right down and simply be present. Water features add a calming soundtrack throughout, and the careful use of colour — from deep purples and burnt oranges to soft creams and vivid greens — means the gardens feel alive and ever-changing.



Colourful Planting & Water Features

The planting at Delta is considered and generous, with sweeping beds that shift beautifully through the seasons. Ornamental grasses catch the light in autumn, while summer brings an abundance of colour that makes the gardens feel almost theatrical in the best possible way. The water features — from quiet reflective pools to gently moving streams — are woven throughout the design, adding movement and a sense of tranquillity that is genuinely hard to leave behind.



There are sheltered seating areas dotted throughout, perfect for sitting quietly with a flask of tea and watching the world slow down around you. We found ourselves lingering far longer than planned, which is always the mark of a place well worth visiting.

Plan Your Visit to Delta

Getting there: Delta Sensory Gardens is located at Strawhall, Carlow Town, Co. Carlow. It is easily reached by car from Dublin in under 90 minutes, and Carlow town is well served by Bus Éireann and Irish Rail connections from Dublin Heuston.

Opening hours vary by season, so we recommend checking the Delta Sensory Gardens website before you visit. The gardens are generally open from spring through to late autumn, with some seasonal variations.

Best time to visit: Late spring and early summer bring the most vivid colour, but the gardens are genuinely lovely in every season. Autumn, in particular, offers beautiful warm tones and a quieter, more contemplative atmosphere.

Combine your visit: Delta pairs wonderfully with a stroll through Carlow town, a visit to Carlow Cathedral, or a trip to Huntington Castle in nearby Clonegal. See our full Carlow guide for a complete day-out itinerary.

Admission: Very reasonable — a genuinely excellent-value day out for individuals, couples and families alike.

Explore More

Watch our Delta Sensory Gardens adventure

Read our full Carlow guide

Location: Strawhall, Carlow Town, Co. Carlow
County: Carlow | Region: Ireland's Ancient East

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Huntington Castle

Tucked away in the quiet village of Clonegal on the Carlow–Wexford border, Huntington Castle is one of Ireland's most fascinating and atmospheric historic homes. Built in 1625 on the site of an ancient abbey, this sprawling castle has been home to the Durdin-Robertson family for generations — and it shows in every creaking floorboard and moss-covered wall.

The gardens alone are worth the journey. Sweeping lawns, ancient yew hedges, a walled garden and a river walk along the Derry River make this one of the most quietly beautiful demesnes in the southeast. It feels genuinely lived-in, gloriously unhurried, and completely unlike the polished heritage sites you might expect.



Grand Interiors & Unusual History

Inside, the castle is a treasure trove of period furniture, family portraits, and the kind of glorious clutter that only centuries of continuous occupation can produce. Grand fireplaces, stone-flagged floors and rooms stuffed with curiosities give Huntington an intimacy that larger stately homes often lack.

But the real talking point lies beneath the castle. The basement houses the Temple of Isis, the headquarters of the Fellowship of Isis — a worldwide spiritual movement



founded by Olivia Durdin-Robertson in 1976. The temple is an extraordinary, otherworldly space carved from the castle's ancient foundations, filled with goddess statues, candles and sacred objects from around the world. Whether you're drawn to its spiritual significance or simply its sheer strangeness, it is utterly unforgettable.

Location: Clonegal, Co. Carlow, Ireland — on the Wicklow and Wexford borders, approx. 1.5 hrs from Dublin.



" History Around Every Corner "

From the ancient abbey foundations beneath your feet to the family portraits lining every wall, Huntington Castle doesn't just tell history — it lives it. Every room, every corridor, every shadowed corner holds a story waiting to be discovered. This is one of those rare places where the past feels genuinely present, and where no two visits are ever quite the same. Come curious, leave captivated.

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Plan Your Visit to Huntington Castle

Getting There: Huntington Castle sits in the village of Clonegal, Co. Carlow, just across the border from Co. Wexford and within easy reach of Co. Wicklow. It makes a perfect stop on a wider Ireland's Ancient East road trip.

Opening Times: The castle opens for guided tours during the summer season and by appointment at other times of year. Check ahead before visiting as hours can vary.

The Gardens: Open more frequently than the castle interior, the grounds are ideal for a peaceful wander at any time of year. The river walk is especially lovely in autumn when the trees turn golden.

The Temple of Isis: Included on guided tours of the castle — do not miss it. Nothing quite prepares you for the experience of stepping into this extraordinary subterranean space.

Nearby: Combine your visit with the beautiful Altamont Gardens just a short drive away, or explore the wider Carlow countryside with its wealth of historic sites, walking trails and welcoming villages.

We've explored Huntington Castle in full — the grand rooms, the walled garden, the river walk, and yes, the extraordinary temple beneath it all. Follow the links below to join us on the adventure.

- ▶ **Explore Huntington Castle with us**
- ▶ **Read our full Carlow guide**

Country Estates

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Wells House & Gardens

Tucked away in the rolling countryside of County Wexford, Wells House & Gardens is one of Ireland's most enchanting Victorian country estates — and one that far too few travellers have discovered. The house itself is a stunning example of Victorian architecture, its elegant facade and grand proportions speaking to a era of ambition, craftsmanship and refined country living.

The gardens are the true showstopper. Sprawling woodlands, manicured formal gardens and winding pathways invite you to slow down and take it all in. There are woodland walks that feel genuinely wild and wonderfully peaceful, a walled garden brimming with colour, and water features that add a tranquil, almost meditative quality to the whole experience.



Stradbally Hall

Most people know Stradbally, County Laois, as the home of Electric Picnic — Ireland's beloved arts and music festival that transforms these grounds every September into something truly spectacular. But here's the thing: Stradbally Hall and its estate are absolutely worth visiting long after the last tent has been packed away.

The Cosby family have called Stradbally Hall home for generations, and their stewardship of this magnificent estate is evident at every turn. The house itself is a grand and



characterful country mansion, its history woven into the very fabric of the building. The grounds are expansive and beautifully kept, with mature woodland walks, open parkland and a real sense of aristocratic Irish rural life.

Beyond the famous festival field, the estate hosts the Irish Steam Preservation Society's annual rally — a wonderfully eccentric and charming event that draws enthusiasts from across the island. The village of Stradbally itself is quietly pretty, with an old-world charm that pairs perfectly with the grandeur of the hall.



Feature: Victorian Splendour & Estate Life

Ireland's country estates are among its most underrated treasures. From the Victorian grandeur of Wells House in Wexford to the storied parklands of Stradbally Hall in Laois, these magnificent properties offer a window into a world of architectural splendour, carefully tended gardens and centuries of family history. Whether you're a lover of heritage architecture, woodland walks, formal gardens or simply a peaceful afternoon away from the ordinary, Ireland's Ancient East delivers in the most elegant fashion imaginable.

Both estates sit within easy driving distance of one another, making them ideal companions for a dedicated country house day trip — or better still, a leisurely overnight stay in the region.

Hidden Gems of Ireland's Ancient East

Ireland's Ancient East is home to some of the island's most rewarding and least-visited country estates. This November, we're shining a light on two very different but equally wonderful properties that deserve a place on every Irish travel itinerary.

Wells House & Gardens brings Victorian elegance and glorious woodland gardens to County Wexford, while Stradbally Hall in County Laois offers a fascinating glimpse behind the famous Electric Picnic headlines into a genuinely historic and characterful family estate.

Explore Wells House & Gardens

Explore Stradbally Hall

Christmas Markets

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Wrocław Christmas Market

We visited Wrocław on a previous trip and fell completely in love with its festive magic. The market in the Old Town Market Square is one of the most atmospheric in all of Europe — rows of wooden stalls glowing with warm amber light, the scent of mulled wine and roasted almonds drifting through the crisp winter air, and the magnificent Gothic Town Hall as your backdrop.





Kraków in Three Days

Kraków is one of those cities that gets under your skin from the very first moment. We spent three wonderful days here on a previous Christmas market trip, and the memories have stayed with us ever since. The Main Market Square — Rynek Główny — transforms into a fairy-tale scene each December, with a towering Christmas tree, artisan stalls selling amber jewellery, hand-painted ornaments and steaming żurek soup. Beyond the market, Kraków rewards every curious traveller: Wawel Castle looming over the Vistula, the haunting history of Kazimierz, and the warm hospitality of the locals in every café and milk bar you wander into. Three days is enough to fall in love — but not nearly enough to see everything.

This feature is based on a previous trip and is shared as Christmas market inspiration. Browse Christmas Market Tours to plan your own adventure.



Cologne Christmas Magic

If you are looking for a classic, grand-scale European Christmas market experience, Cologne delivers in spectacular fashion. We visited on a previous trip and were immediately struck by the sheer scale and variety — Cologne actually hosts several distinct markets across the city, each with its own character and charm.

The Cathedral Market (Domplatz) is the most iconic, set in the shadow of the magnificent twin-spired Cologne Cathedral. The contrast of the Gothic stonework against the twinkling market lights is something you simply have to see in person. The Harbour Market (Heinzels Wintermärchen) adds a romantic waterside dimension, with reflections shimmering on the Rhine.

Previous Trips · Festive Inspiration for Your Winter Adventures

The three destinations featured on this page — Wrocław, Kraków and Cologne — are places we have visited on previous trips and adored. We are sharing them here as genuine inspiration to help you plan your own magical Christmas market adventure. These are not reports from a current-year visit; they are warm recommendations drawn from real experience.

Whether you are dreaming of a weekend break or a longer festive escape, European Christmas markets offer some of the most joyful travel experiences imaginable. From the spiced warmth of a Glühwein cradled in both hands to the glow of fairy lights on centuries-old architecture, there is truly nothing quite like it.

Use the links throughout this page to explore further, watch our travel videos, and browse tours. We have curated a Christmas Markets Guide on the website with practical tips on timing, budgeting and the best stalls to seek out in each city.

AFFILIATE DISCLOSURE: SOME LINKS ON THIS PAGE MAY EARN US A SMALL COMMISSION AT NO EXTRA COST TO YOU

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TWO TRAVELLERS. ENDLESS ADVENTURES.

Plenty of laughs along the way!

❤️ A Huge Thank You From Two for the Row'd!

Before we go, we just want to say a massive THANK YOU to everyone who's been following our adventures, watching our videos, liking, commenting and supporting Two for the Row'd! It genuinely means the world to us. ❤️

We're loving sharing our travels with you, and there's plenty more to come! If you're enjoying our newsletters, we'd be delighted if you could share them with your friends and encourage them to sign up at www.twofortherowd.com. The more, the merrier! 😂✈️

And don't wander too far, because our next newsletter will be coming to you with all the gossip, adventures and probably a few mishaps from our trip to Poznań, Poland! 🇵🇱🎄 Who knows what we'll get up to?! Until then, thanks for being part of our journey, and happy travels!

Much love,
Two for the Row'd ❤️✈️

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THANK YOU FOR TRAVELLING WITH US — SEE YOU NEXT MONTH FOR MORE HIDDEN GEMS & ADVENTURES!